

FILMDOM'S NEW PET OBSESSION

WITH PLOTLINES TWIRLING AROUND OUR FOUR-LEGGED FRIENDS, 2026 IS THE YEAR OF THE PET IN INDIAN CINEMA, ESPECIALLY THEIR CAPACITY TO LOVE AND HEAL, AND THE NEED FOR US TO RECIPROCATE WITH EMPATHY

By SUHANI SINGH

IN **2022, during the downward arc of the COVID-19 pandemic,** filmmaker Amit Rai saw a dog adoption post on Facebook. He didn't care that it wasn't a pedigreed breed or that it had a slight limp in a hind leg. "I felt proud of myself, thinking I will look after him," he says. But the pride soon evaporated as Rai realised "*woh mujhko paal raha hai* (he's taking care of me)!" Rai describes the arrival of Oscar as a life-changing experience, one that would inspire him to write a script summing up the emotions he felt for his pet. The result was *Ohh My Dog* (*OMD*), in which Oscar plays Momo, a lost pet whose search brings a tech-savvy kid up against corrupt police officers and illegal dog-meat mafia. The scene-stealer, though, was Bruno, a trained indie dog who runs, sniffs, barks and howls to find a child kidnapped by an organ trafficking ring.

OMD has its flaws, from plot deviations to a protracted run time, but its four-legged heroes have the audiences go